Yvonne Y. Tam

Department of Philosophy, Northwestern University, 633 Clark St, Evanston, IL 60208
yvonne.tam@northwestern.edu
www.yytam.com

RESEARCH & TEACHING INTERESTS

AOS: Ethics, History of Moral Theory, Moral Psychology

AOC: Social & Political Philosophy, Feminist Philosophy, Philosophy of Disability

ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT

Northwestern University, Brady Postdoctoral Faculty Fellow — Sept. 2025—Present

University of California Riverside, Visiting Lecturer — Sept. 2022—Jun. 2025

University of California at Riverside, Aug. 2012—Dec. 2018
Teaching Assistant, Associate Instructor

EDUCATION

PhD in Philosophy, University of California Riverside — 2025
Dissertation: *A Kantian Duty of Moral Self-Love*
Committee: Andrews Reath (chair), Agnieszka Jaworska, Michael Nelson, Andreja Novakovic

MA in Philosophy, University of Wisconsin Milwaukee — 2011
Thesis: *Justice for the Cognitively Disabled: Obligations to the Margins of Our Moral Community.*
Committee: Carla Bagnoli, Blaine Neufeld, Andrea Westlund

BA in Philosophy and Gender Studies—Double Major — 2007

PEER-REVIEWED PRESENTATIONS[1]

"Respecting Vulnerability: Active Sympathy & Inner Freedom in Kant's Doctrine of Virtue"
- Symposium paper, APA Pacific, Mar. 2027

"Rethinking Sympathy, Agency, and the Practice of Moral Community"
- Group Agency & Metaethics Workshop, International Social Ontology Society at the University of Vienna, Sept. 2026

"Beyond Self-Respect: Towards a Kantian Duty of Moral Self-Love."
- Mark Sanders Early Career Mentoring Workshop for Early Career Women Faculty in Philosophy, Jun. 2025
- Love and Care Workshop at Harvard University, Sept. 2024
- Leipzig University Doctoral Conference, Jun. 2024

[1] Conference participation following blind review of papers, abstracts, or applications.

"The Structure of Authority in Meta-Ethical Justification."
- Braga National Meeting for the Portuguese Society of Analytic Philosophy at the University of Minho Sept. 2012
- Salzburg Conference for Analytic Philosophy Aug. 2012

OTHER PRESENTATIONS

Self-Love & Solidarity (Monograph Proposal)
- Nominated for Kaplan Institute for the Humanities Dissertation to Book Workshop at Northwestern University, Mar. 2025

Comments for Bas Tönissen, "Kant's Concept of the Heart and Its Development." Pacific APA, Mar. 2025

"Kantian Moral Friendship and Two Kinds of Self-love" UCR Philosophy Colloquia, Nov. 2024

PAPERS & MANUSCRIPTS

In Preparation [2]

"Beyond Self-Respect: Towards a Kantian Duty of Moral Self-Love"

"Moral Friendship & Two Kinds of Self-love"

"Respecting Vulnerability: Sympathy and Inner Freedom in Kant's Doctrine of Virtue"

"Sympathy, Agency, and the Practice of Moral Community"

Public Philosophy

"*The Moral Life* : Thinking for Oneself by Thinking Together" APA Syllabus Showcase Blog, Oct. 21, 2026.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Northwestern University, Visiting Faculty Fellow
Philosophy of Ethics & Authenticity First-Year Writing Seminar (Winter 2026)
The Moral Life (Spring 2026)
The Good Life (scheduled Winter 2027)
The Good Society (scheduled Spring 2027)

University of California Riverside, Primary Lecturer/Instructor
Ethics, class-size (Spring 2025)
Philosophy of Justice, class-size (7 quarters)
Philosophy of Feminism (Spring 2024)
Ethics and the Meaning of Life (Fall 2022)
Introduction to Philosophy (Summers 2012, 2013)

[2] Manuscripts available upon request.

ORGANIZATIONAL & SERVICE ROLES

2026-27 Cohort, Reflective & Effective Teaching Program in the Searle Center for Advancing Learning and Teaching at Northwestern University

Northwestern Society for the Theory of Ethics and Politics, organizer 2026, 2027

Referee: *Croatian Journal of Philosophy; Medusa: An Undergraduate Journal of Philosophy*

PhiloSOPHIA: A Transcontinental Society for Feminism conference, program committee member, Texas A & M University, April 2025.

American Philosophical Association member

North American Kant Society member

UCR Minorities and Philosophy

"Fichtean Kantianism in 19th Century Ethics" by Michelle Koch, chair, APA Eastern Dec. 2015

Research Assistant to Agnieszka Jaworska,"The Grounds of Moral Status" Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, AY 2012/2013

DISSERTATION: A KANTIAN DUTY OF MORAL SELF-LOVE

Moral practice often invokes self-love, there's the dictum that you must love yourself if you are to love others, and imperatives to "radical self-love" in social justice discourse have become an urgent call to solidarity and resistance for oppressed groups to have "pride" in their marginalized identities. Although appeals to self-love pervade moral life, it remains largely neglected in the philosophical literature on moral self-regard. Moreover, the moral tradition tends to treat self-love as an inevitable feature of human psychology that we must curb for the sake of others. Indeed Kant infamously regards self-love as the chief antagonist to morality. His is paradigmatic of the moral tradition's treatment of self-love as a form of self-interest and thus non-moral (if not immoral).

Despite Kant's purported hostility to self-love, I articulate a Kantian moral theoretical basis for a moral kind of self-love, develop a theory of self-love, and argue that as members of the moral community, we have a duty of self-love because this kind of self-regard is central to our moral relations, and thus moral agency. I take my lead from Kant's foundational concept of the value of humanity, which properly understood, identifies its positive requirements towards others with practical love: to share in the ends of subjects who are ends-in-themselves. As an alternative to Kant's more famous notion of self-interested self-love, *moral* self-love positively values *oneself* as an end-in-itself. As practical, moral self-love is a form of self-regard that transforms how we relate to the value of our ends. My ends are important not just because I care about them, but they're worth caring about because I as a person matter.

Chapter 1 distinguishes the kind of moral self-love at issue from prudential self-interest, and related modes of moral self-regard such as *virtuous self-esteem* and *self-respect*. I consider cases of failures of self-love that seem morally salient, and contend that prevailing accounts of moral self-regard are inadequate to justify them as failures of *moral* concern. Candidate accounts of moral duties of self-regard come in roughly two varieties. In virtue ethics, we find positive self-regard that is merited by virtuous but optional moral achievement. The deontic moral tradition offers a robust treatment of perfect duties of self-respect. But neither fully explain the moral significance of the failures at issue,

why others may have a moral interest in our own self-love, nor do they explain the centrality of self-love in contemporary moral practice. The rest of my dissertation develops a unified theory of a moral duty to self-love that explains how proper self-love shares the same moral grounds as other-regarding love, the moral significance of failures of self-love and its attending duty, and self-love's role in sustaining our moral relations, and thus moral agency.

Chapter 2 argues that the view of practical love we find in Kant's account of moral friendship presupposes a capacity for moral self-love. Moral friendship is characterized by reciprocity and joint willing, and is distinguished from non-moral friendship in that it is a valuing stance towards each other's ends that is grounded in the recognition of one another's dignity as persons. So, what makes a love relation moral in nature is the moral grounds for adopting ends for another's sake. This understanding of the moral relation of value in which persons stand to their ends constitutes a crucial area of practical proficiency with the moral concept of persons required for joint willing. Moral love thus endows the standpoint of friendship with a cognitively complex and morally sophisticated volitional structure. I share in my friend's ends out of the recognition that her ends matter because she matters. Since joint willing underwrites sharing ends in moral friendship, participating in such relations requires the ability to set my own ends on grounds that my friend can share, which is to say, out of recognition of the value of my own person.

Chapter 3 argues that failures of moral self-love constitute a moral deficiency because they demonstrate a deficient grasp of the moral concept of persons as it pertains to oneself. Unlike failures of self-respect, however, they aren't just cases of undermining one's equal moral standing by waiving one's claim to moral rights. Rather, they display a relation to the value of one's ends that regards one's worth as conditional on one's merits or success. Distorting the relation of value in which persons stand to their ends therefore contradicts the grounds for adopting ends out of recognition for the moral worth of persons. Failures of moral self-love deny one's humanity the proper role in guiding one's valuing agency. Since proficiency with the moral concept of persons requires recognizing its' *practical* role, such failures exhibit a defective moral self-conception. Failures of self-love thus exhibit both deficient moral understanding and undermines our duty to sustain a moral relation to ourselves. For this reason, moral self-love, on my view, is not a morally virtuous yet optional achievement, but rather a *duty*.

My final chapter articulates self-love's role in moral agency by functioning to counter the various risks to the basis of proper self-worth. I pursue a novel reading of Kant's account of self-conceit, and his view of finite rational wills. I contend that vulnerability to the success of our ends is partially constitutive of valuing for agents with a sensible nature. Setting ends thus introduces a susceptibility to assessing our own and one another's worth in terms of success or failure of those ends. How we relate to one another and the description under which we value and assess the quality of our relationships is structured by an implicit conception of our worthiness to one another. In that case, sharing ends, the defining activity of participation in moral relations, requires the capacity to manage one's vulnerability to either one's own ends, or to those of another. Since valuing necessitates some positive description of value, one resists comparative or dehumanizing ascription of personal worth *by* supplanting it with a morally authoritative one. This is just one's value as a person, with the power to create value through setting ends on grounds that can be shared from the standpoint of a subject who has moral love for me, whether that is another or myself. My dissertation concludes with implications that my theory of moral self-love has for rethinking the purported tension between love and duty, and re-evaluating our understanding of moral agency and the self-conception that's presupposed in our capacity to participate in moral relations. My analysis of moral self-love vindicates a central role for practical love in Kant's moral psychology and moral theory generally, with meta-normative implications for the connection between moral understanding and sensibility.